Calum McNamara

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Areas of specialization and competence

AOS Decision Theory, Epistemology, Philosophy of AI
AOC Ethics, Logic, Metaphysics, Philosophies of Language, Mind, and Science

Employment

Indiana University, Bloomington
2025– Assistant Professor of Philosophy
Affiliated Faculty in Cognitive Science
Yale University
2024–25 Postdoctoral Associate

Education

2024 PhD in Philosophy, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor
2018 BA in Philosophy, King's College London (First Class)

Papers

('⋆' indicates first or co-first authorship.)

Articles published in journals and conference proceedings

Forthcoming "Only Causal Decision Theory Defers to Experts"
Journal of Philosophy

Forthcoming "Desire-as-Belief in Context"
Mind

2026 "A Behavioural and Representational Evaluation of Goal-Directedness in Language Model Agents" (Raghu Arghal,⋆ Phoebe Chen,⋆ Niall Dalton,⋆ Evgenii Kortukov,⋆ Calum McNamara,⋆ Angelos Nalmpantis,⋆ Moksh Nirvaan,⋆ Gabriele Sarti,⋆ and Mario Giulianelli⋆)
Proceedings of the 43rd International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML)

2025 "Dutch Books, Indicative Conditionals, and Rational Updating" (Calum McNamara⋆ and Snow Zhang⋆)
Proceedings of the 24th Amsterdam Colloquium

2024 "Causal Decision Theory, Context, and Determinism"
Philosophy and Phenomenological Research, vol. 109, no. 1, pp. 226–260

2022 "The Punctuated Equilibrium of Scientific Change: A Bayesian Network Model" (Patrick Grim,⋆ Frank Seidl, Calum McNamara, Isabell N. Astor, and Caroline Diaso)
Synthese, vol. 200, no. 4, no. 297

2022 "Scientific Theories as Bayesian Nets: Structure and Evidence Sensitivity" (Patrick Grim,⋆ Frank Seidl, Calum McNamara, Hinton Rago, Isabell N. Astor, Caroline Diaso, and Peter Ryner)
Philosophy of Science, vol. 89, no. 1, pp. 42–69

Work in progress

Under Review
"Bringing About the Good, from Behind the Veil of Ignorance", R&R, *Ethics*
"Why (Not) Conditionalize?" (Calum McNamara* and Snow Zhang*)
"Are Suppositional Decision Theories Self-recommending?"
"Emergent Alignment and the Projectability of Ethical Personas" (Guillermo Del Pinal,* Youngchan Lee,* Calum McNamara, and Alejandro Pérez Carballo)
"Corrigibility and Causal Belief Revision in the Off-Switch Game"
"Learning 'If'"

In Preparation
"Accuracy and Epistemic Modalities" (Mikayla Kelley,* Calum McNamara,* Richard Roth,* and Snow Zhang*)
"Multidimensional Epistemic Value"
"Decision Theory from the Ground Up"
"Is Utilitarianism Really Self-defeating?"
"Counterfactual Similarity Without Modal Fragility" (Calum McNamara* and Paolo Santorio*)
"On the Representation of Goals in Language Model Agents" (Calum McNamara,* Raghu Arghal, Niall Dalton, Guillermo Del Pinal, and Mario Giulianelli)
"A Formal Theory of Agency" (David Abel,* Calum McNamara,* and Benjamin Santi*)

Selected presentations

('★' indicates refereed; '†' indicates invited.)

"Why (Not) Conditionalize?" (Calum McNamara* and Snow Zhang*)
Jul 2026 Australian National University†
Apr 2025 Massachusetts Institute of Technology (presented by Snow Zhang)
Dec 2024 The 24th Amsterdam Colloquium, University of Amsterdam★
Mar 2024 University of Maryland, College Park (presented by Snow Zhang)
Feb 2023 University of Texas at Austin†

"A Behavioural and Representational Evaluation of Goal-Directedness in Language Model Agents" (Raghu Arghal, Phoebe Chen, Niall Dalton, Evgenii Kortukov, Calum McNamara, Angelos Nalmpantis, Moksh Nirvaan, Gabriele Sarti, and Mario Giulianelli)
Jul 2026 43rd International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML)★
Apr 2026 Agents in the Wild Workshop, International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)★
Apr 2026 World Models Workshop, International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)★
Mar 2026 Algorithmic Alignment Group, MIT (presented by Gabriele Sarti)

"Bringing About the Good, from Behind the Veil of Ignorance"
Jun 2026 Formal Epistemology Workshop, University of Colorado, Boulder★
Nov 2025 University of Texas at Austin†
Oct 2025 Formal Approaches to Rationality and Meaning, University of Maryland, College Park★

"Accuracy and Epistemic Modalities" (Mikayla Kelley,* Calum McNamara,* Richard Roth,* and Snow Zhang*)
May 2026 Epistemic Utility for Imprecise Probability Conference, University of Bristol†
Feb 2026 APA Central Division Meeting, Invited Symposium (presented by Snow Zhang)†
May 2025 Formal Epistemology Workshop, University of Iceland★
Apr 2025 Princeton University†
Dec 2023 Accuracy Workshop, University of Chicago†

"What Can AI Teach Us About Natural Properties?"
Feb 2026 London School of Economics†

"Suppositional Decision Theories are Self-undermining"
Jan 2026 APA Eastern Division Meeting, Colloquium⋆
Apr 2025 Richard Pettigrew's Locke Lectures Tailgate, Northeastern University†

"Causal Decision Theory and the Off-switch"
Oct 2025 Indiana Logic Seminar, Indiana University, Bloomington†

"Only Causal Decision Theory Defers to Experts"
May 2025 Method, Theory, and Reality Workshop, University of Massachusetts, Amherst†
Apr 2025 APA Pacific Division Meeting, Symposium⋆
Jun 2024 Workshop on Decision, Desire, and Diffusion, University of California, Berkeley†

"Learning 'If'"
Jan 2025 University of Toronto†
Dec 2024 Chicago Area Philosophical Exchange, University of Chicago†
Nov 2024 Duke-UNC Epistemology Conference⋆
May 2024 World Sequences Day Conference, University of Connecticut, Storrs†
May 2024 Workshop on Matthew Mandelkern's *Bounded Meaning*, University of Massachusetts, Amherst†

"Most Counterfactuals are Indeterminate"
Nov 2024 New York Philosophy of Language Workshop, New York University†
Mar 2024 Rationality and Reality Workshop, University of California, Berkeley†

"Desire-as-Belief in Context"
Oct 2024 Columbia University†
Jan 2024 Indiana University, Bloomington†

"Is Polarization Really Rational?" (Eduardo J. Martinez* and Calum McNamara*)
Feb 2024 APA Central Division Meeting, Colloquium⋆
Jun 2021 Michigan-MIT Social Philosophy Workshop, University of Michigan⋆

"Counterfactuals in the Image of Chance"
Jan 2023 APA Eastern Division Meeting, Colloquium⋆

"Humean Causation"
Apr 2022 UT Austin Graduate Philosophy Conference, University of Texas at Austin⋆

"Causation, Determinism, and Decision-making"
Feb 2022 APA Central Division Meeting, Colloquium⋆

Conference comments

Branden Fitelson, "A Two-Dimensional Theory of Argument Strength—with Applications"
Jan 2026 Ranch Metaphysics Workshop

Caleb Fawell, "Cautious Monotonicity: Not Cautious Enough?"
Mar 2025 APA Pacific Division Meeting, Colloquium

Ginger Schultheis, "Might' Counterfactuals"
Jan 2025 APA Eastern Division Meeting, Invited Symposium

Commentator at Large
Apr 2024 Northeastern Epistemology Workshop

Shamik Dasgupta, "Practical Nihilism"
Mar 2024 Michigan Spring Colloquium

Jim Hutchison, "Moral Principles and Normative Generality"
Apr 2023 APA Pacific Division Meeting, Colloquium

Jason Konek, "Aggregating Imprecise Probabilities Using Epistemic Utilities" (Calum McNamara and Elise Woodard)

May 2019 Michigan Philosophy Alumni Conference
Jennifer Carr, "Epistemic Observation, Pragmatic Intervention"
Jan 2019 Michigan Spring Colloquium

Grants, honors, awards, and fellowships

2026–27 Coefficient Giving, AI Upskilling Grant ($43,000 for partial teaching relief)
Summer 2026 Jesse Fine Fellowship ($5,000 award to develop an AI ethics course at IU, Bloomington)
Summer 2026 IU Global Primary Partner Faculty Grant (to visit the Australian National University for one month; $4,000)
2023–24 Cornwell Prize, University of Michigan (full year fellowship)
2022 Rackham One-term Dissertation Fellowships, University of Michigan, Fall and Spring semesters
Summer 2022 Rackham Research Grant, University of Michigan
2022 Faculty Prize for Excellence in Teaching, University of Michigan
Summer 2021 Weinberg Pre-doctoral Fellowship, University of Michigan
2018 Jelf Medal Nomination, King's College London
2018 Arts and Humanities Research Council Studentship, for graduate study at Oxford (declined)
2018 King's College London MPhilStud Bursary, for graduate study at King's College London (declined)
2016 Bob Meyer Memorial Scholarship, for study at the Australian National University

Teaching

Indiana

Spring 2027 Phil 241: Foundations of Artificial Intelligence Ethics (planned)
Fall 2026 Phil 562: Introduction to Bayesian Epistemology (graduate seminar)
Spring 2026 Phil 105: Critical Reasoning
Spring 2026 Phil 360: Introduction to the Philosophy of Mind
Fall 2025 Phil 105: Critical Reasoning
Fall 2025 Phil 352: Logic and Philosophy

Yale

Spring 2025 Phil 210/Phil 510: Formal Philosophical Methods
Fall 2024 Phil 115: First-order Logic

Michigan (lead instructor)

Summer 2023 Phil 303: Introduction to Symbolic Logic

Michigan (teaching assistant)

Spring 2023 Phil 345: Mind and Language, for James M. Joyce
Fall 2021 Phil 303: Introduction to Symbolic Logic, for Gordon Belot
Spring 2021 Phil 444: Groups and Choices, for Brian Weatherson (online due to COVID)
Fall 2020 Phil 340: Minds and Machines, for Eric Swanson (online due to COVID)
Spring 2020 Phil 250: Changing the World, for David Manley
Fall 2019 Phil 305: Introduction to Formal Philosophical Methods, for Brian Weatherson

Supervision

Alexander Fiander, PhD Qualifying Committee
Daniel Gaines, PhD Qualifying Committee

Extramural teaching

Summer 2026 Conditionals and Decision Theory, European Summer School in Logic, Language, and Information, with Paolo Santorio

Service

Outreach and public-facing work

2026 Panel discussion on AI, Indiana University, PPE Society

2025–26 Introducing: Project Telos, blog post series outlining results from an AI project (co-authored with Mario Giulianelli and 7 others)

2026 Invited public talk on the theme of AI and human flourishing, Indiana University

Refereeing of journal submissions

Acta Analytica; *Analysis*; *American Philosophical Quarterly* (4); *Asian Journal of Philosophy*; *Australasian Journal of Philosophy* (3); *Canadian Journal of Philosophy*; *Ergo* (2); *Erkenntnis*; *European Journal of Philosophy*; *Inquiry* (2); *Journal of Mathematical Philosophy*; *Journal of Philosophy*; *Linguistics and Philosophy*; *Mind* (2); *Minds and Machines*; *Pacific Philosophical Quarterly* (2); *Philosophical Studies* (4); *Philosophical Quarterly*; *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research* (2); *Philosophy of Science*; *Review of Symbolic Logic*; *Synthese* (3); *Theoria*; *Theory and Decision*

Refereeing of conference submissions

Formal Approaches to Rationality and Meaning (FARM) Conference, 2025 (2); Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence (AAAI) Conference, 2027 (4); International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR), 2026 (3)

Refereeing of grant proposals, etc.

Swiss National Science Foundation

Organizing

2026– Faculty Advisor, IU Students' AI Safety and Alignment Club

2026– IU Colloquium Committee

2026– IU Faculty Work-in-progress Group

2020–24 Michigan Philosophy Weekly Tea

2018–24 Michigan Epistemology Working Group

2018–19 Michigan Philosophy Spring Colloquium

2016–18 King's College London Formal Philosophy Reading Group

Mentorship

2020–22 COMPASS Mentor

2022–24 Graduate Student Mentor (GSM), University of Michigan

Other service

2021–24 APA Session Chair: Eastern, Central, Pacific

2019 Editor, *Philosopher's Annual*

2018–19 Graduate Member, Admissions Committee, University of Michigan

2016–17 Co-author and tutor of a training course, "Reflexive strategies for better judgment and decision-making", for the British Civil Service, with Julien Dutant and Alexandru Marcoci

Other skills and experience

Academic visits

Summer 2026 — Visiting Researcher, Australian National University

Additional education

Fall 2025 — Supervised Program in Alignment Research (SPAR). Research Fellow on the Project "Towards a Science of AI Agency: Modeling, Measuring, and Intervening on Goal-Directed Behaviour in AI Systems", led by Mario Giulianelli. Team leader for the Reverse Engineering Sub-team.

Aug 2022 — European Summer School in Logic, Language, and Information (ESSLLI), National University of Ireland, Galway, Ireland

Fall 2022 — Visiting Graduate Student, New York University

Dec 2016 — Logic Summer School, Australian National University, Canberra, Australia

Programming

Python (PyTorch, NumPy, einops); TransformerLens

Last updated: October 16, 2026